WME Group (fka Endeavor)

Business Development Dossier

Industry	**Media, Entertainment & Sports**
Revenue	**$6B**
Employees	**10,000**
Ideal Customer Profile Score	**93**

ICP SCORING MODEL


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ICP = Signals + Revenue + Employees + Fit   (max 100)
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Signals (0-35)	Top 4 signals scored; each = base(60%) + recency bonus <30d: 40% | <90d: 30% | <180d: 20% | older: 10%
Revenue (0-25)	$500M-$10B sweet spot -> 70-100% of 25 pts Below $500M -> pro-rata x 0.5 | Above $10B -> 60%
Employees (0-20)	2,000+ preferred (70-100%) | 500-2K partial (50-70%) Below 500 -> pro-rata x 0.3
Fit (0-20)	High-fit types: reorg, transformation, M&A, hiring, funding, partnership -> 5 pts ea (max 12) + diversity 2/type (max 8)

Prepared March 19, 2026

McChrystal Group

Leadership Advisory & Organizational Effectiveness

SECTION 1

Organization Snapshot

Legal Name	Endeavor Group Holdings, Inc. (d/b/a WME Group)
Headquarters	Beverly Hills, California (9601 Wilshire Boulevard)
Founded	2009

Ownership

Private - PE-backed by Silver Lake (majority owner since March 2025 take-private). Key equity holders include Silver Lake, Mubadala Investment Company, Goldman Sachs Asset Management, and rolled-over management equity from Emanuel, Shapiro, and others. WME Group retains 61% stake in publicly traded TKO Group Holdings (NYSE: TKO).

Footprint

Global operations across 30+ countries. Primary offices in Beverly Hills (HQ), New York City, Nashville, London, and Sydney. The WME talent agency operates primarily in the U.S. with growing international reach. 160over90 and IMG Licensing have broader global footprints. TKO (majority-owned subsidiary) has significant international operations through UFC and WWE.

SECTION 1b

Company Overview

WME Group (formerly Endeavor) is a global entertainment, sports, and content company that houses the William Morris Endeavor talent agency and holds a 61% stake in TKO Group (UFC + WWE). Taken private by Silver Lake in a $25B deal in March 2025, the company rebranded from Endeavor and underwent a complete leadership transition - founder Ari Emanuel moved to executive chairman while Mark Shapiro became president and managing partner.

SECTION 2

Financial Health & Growth Stage

Understanding WME Group's financial position and trajectory is critical to framing any engagement conversation.

Revenue: Estimated ~$6B consolidated (WME Group + 61% TKO stake). TKO alone reported $4.735B in 2025 revenue with guidance for $5.675-5.775B in 2026. WME Group's standalone revenue (agency commissions, 160over90, IMG Licensing) is [INFERRED] in the $1-1.5B range after divestitures.

Profitability: TKO generated $1.585B adjusted EBITDA in 2025 (up 47% YoY) and $546M net income. WME Group standalone profitability is unavailable as a private company, but talent agencies typically operate at 15-25% margins [INFERRED].

Key Pressures: (1) Significant debt load from $25B leveraged buyout - Silver Lake will demand efficient capital allocation and margin expansion. (2) Shapiro's dual-mandate across WME Group and TKO creates bandwidth constraints at the top. (3) Post-divestiture identity crisis - remaining WME Group must justify its standalone existence. (4) Talent retention risk as agents may question whether PE ownership changes the culture they signed up for.

Tailwinds: (1) TKO's explosive growth ($7.7B UFC Paramount deal, $5B WWE Netflix deal) generates massive cash flow. (2) Silver Lake's track record of scaling portfolio companies provides operational expertise. (3) Entertainment industry consolidation creates opportunities for a well-capitalized talent agency. (4) 160over90's brand marketing capabilities are highly relevant in the creator economy era.

SECTION 3

Leadership Team Profiles

The following contacts are recommended as primary outreach targets - champion-level leaders who feel the organizational pain daily and can sponsor McChrystal internally.

Mark Shapiro - President & Managing Partner, WME Group; President & COO, TKO Group [PRIORITY TARGET]

Former CEO of Dick Clark Productions and Six Flags Entertainment. Career media executive with deep experience in live events, sports rights, and entertainment operations. Known as a 'hard-charging, creative, and determined leader' (Silver Lake's description). Featured on How Leaders Lead podcast discussing clear expectations and results-driven cultures.

Outreach rationale: Shapiro is the de facto CEO of WME Group and the person who must build a new organizational identity from Endeavor's remains. His dual role across WME Group and TKO makes organizational alignment and cross-functional effectiveness urgent priorities. He is the economic buyer for any enterprise advisory engagement.

Christian Muirhead - Co-Chairman, WME Group [PRIORITY TARGET]

Rose from communications lead to co-chairman. Served as Endeavor's Chief Communications Officer since 2014. Orchestrated communications strategy for 30+ acquisitions and new business launches. Played integral role in Endeavor's IPO readiness. Also oversees government relations, social impact, and architecture teams.

Outreach rationale: As co-chairman with deep institutional knowledge spanning 20 years and experience integrating 30+ acquisitions, Muirhead is a likely internal champion who understands the cultural and structural challenges firsthand. His communications and integration background makes him a natural ally for an organizational transformation engagement.

Additional leadership team members relevant to the engagement:

Ari Emanuel - Executive Chairman, WME Group; CEO & Executive Chair, TKO Group

Legendary talent agent and dealmaker. Co-founded Endeavor talent agency in 1995 after leaving ICM. Architect of Endeavor's aggressive M&A strategy (WME-IMG merger 2009, IPO 2021). Received $175.8M cash payout in Silver Lake deal. Brother of former Chicago Mayor Rahm Emanuel.

Richard Weitz - Co-Chairman, WME Group

Career talent agent. Left ICM with Ari Emanuel to launch Endeavor in 1995. Led WME's TV packaging department. Represents major talent including Tina Fey, Ricky Gervais, Dan Levy. Known for Quarantunes virtual concert series during COVID that raised $26M+ for charities.

Patrick Whitesell - Former Executive Chairman (departed March 2025)

Co-led WME alongside Emanuel for 15+ years. Received $100M cash payout and rolled $265.7M into a new Silver Lake-backed venture investing in sports, media, and entertainment IP. Took WME Football division with him on departure.

SECTION 4

Organizational Culture & Structure

Culture and structure are often where McChrystal Group finds the deepest leverage. The following signals indicate how WME Group operates today and where friction exists.

Organizational Structure

Historically hierarchical and personality-driven - built around Ari Emanuel's centralized authority and agent-principal relationship model. The talent agency business is inherently structured around individual agent relationships (each agent operates as a quasi-independent business). Post-rebrand, WME Group encompasses three main business units: WME (talent agency), 160over90 (marketing agency), and IMG Licensing - each with distinct cultures and operating models. Shapiro's dual role as head of both WME Group and TKO adds a matrixed reporting complexity. The co-chairman structure (Muirhead + Weitz) under Shapiro is a new governance experiment without a clear precedent at the company.

Culture Signals

Glassdoor Data: WME rated 3.4/5 for culture and values; 3.0/5 for work-life balance; Endeavor parent rated 3.5/5 overall (376 reviews). Only 66% of WME employees recommend it to a friend.

Recurring Themes: (1) 'Upper management could not care less about employees' - consistent complaint about exploitation and lack of investment in people. (2) 'Pay your dues' mentality - outdated hazing culture where junior employees endure poor treatment as a rite of passage. (3) Minimal benefits - low vacation days, no 401k match, discouraged PTO usage. (4) 'Huge egos' and hyper-competitive internal dynamics. (5) High career opportunity rating (4.0/5) suggests people stay for access and resume value, not because they're treated well.

McChrystal Relevance: The culture profile is a textbook case for McChrystal's transformation work - a hierarchical, ego-driven organization where information hoarding and internal competition undermine collective effectiveness. The PE transition creates both the mandate and the window to address these issues. Shapiro's stated emphasis on 'clear expectations' and 'results-driven culture' suggests he recognizes the problem. The challenge: agents are the revenue generators and resist process-driven transformation, similar to how special operators initially resisted JSOC's information-sharing mandates.

SECTION 5

Recent News & Trigger Events

The following developments from the past 18 months create urgency and provide natural conversation entry points for engaging WME Group.

1. **2025-03-24 - Silver Lake completes $25B take-private of Endeavor**

   Largest PE take-private in media/entertainment history. Company delisted from NYSE. Silver Lake will demand operational efficiency, clear value creation milestones, and portfolio rationalization - all requiring strong organizational alignment.

2. **2025-03-24 - Ari Emanuel steps down as CEO; Mark Shapiro takes over as President & Managing**

Partner; Patrick Whitesell exits entirely

Triple leadership change at the top removes the founder-CEO and his co-leader simultaneously. Shapiro must establish authority across a company built around Emanuel's personality and relationships. Classic 'founder-to-professional-manager' transition.

3. 2025-03-24 - Company rebrands from Endeavor to WME Group

Identity reset signals strategic pivot back to talent agency roots. Employees, clients, and partners must adapt to new brand, new leadership, and new organizational scope simultaneously - high risk of culture fragmentation.

4. 2025-02-28 - IMG, PBR, and On Location divested to TKO in $3.25B all-stock deal

Stripping major divisions from the parent changes the organizational footprint, reporting lines, and career paths for thousands of employees. Remaining WME Group must redefine its value proposition without these assets.

5. 2025-01-01 - OpenBet and IMG Arena sold in $450M management buyout

Divestiture of sports betting technology signals focus narrowing. Employees from divested units face uncertainty; remaining staff questions what's next.

6. 2025-01-06 - WWE Monday Night Raw debuts on Netflix in $5B, 10-year deal

Landmark deal validates Shapiro's dealmaking prowess at TKO but underscores his divided attention between TKO (where the big growth is) and WME Group (where the organizational challenge is). Partners at WME may question where his priorities lie.

7. 2026-02-27 - TKO reports $4.7B revenue for 2025, announces $1B buyback and $7.7B UFC media rights deal with Paramount

TKO's explosive growth further concentrates Shapiro's attention on the sports/entertainment side. WME Group risks becoming the 'less exciting' part of the portfolio, creating morale and retention challenges for agents and staff.

SECTION 6

McChrystal Fit Assessment

> *Strong fit despite Tier 3 industry classification. The combination of PE take-private, simultaneous CEO departure + new leader installation, corporate rebrand, and massive asset divestitures creates one of the most complex organizational transformation challenges in recent entertainment industry history. The ICP score of 92.7 reflects the density of transformation signals. Shapiro's publicly stated emphasis on 'clear expectations' and 'results-driven culture' suggests philosophical alignment with McChrystal's approach. The $6B revenue and ~10,000 employees place WME Group squarely in the ICP sweet spot for company size.*

Primary Problem

WME Group is undergoing simultaneous CEO transition, corporate identity rebrand, and radical portfolio simplification under new PE ownership - requiring a cohesive organizational operating model to be built essentially from scratch. The dual-mandate leadership (Shapiro running both WME Group and TKO) creates alignment and prioritization challenges across the organization. Legacy culture problems (hierarchical 'pay your dues' mentality, low employee engagement, agent-centric power structures) are incompatible with the leaner, more integrated organization Silver Lake needs.

Best McChrystal Capability Fit

Team of Teams operating model implementation and organizational design/transformation. WME Group's challenge is a textbook case for McChrystal's approach: a formerly sprawling, personality-driven conglomerate must become an aligned, adaptive, cross-functional organization under new leadership. The Team of Teams framework directly addresses the silos between WME agency, 160over90, and IMG Licensing - entities that historically operated as independent fiefdoms. Leadership development for Shapiro's expanded team and culture change initiatives would be natural follow-ons.

Likely Objections to Engagement

'We're an entertainment company - military leadership frameworks don't apply here.' Counter: the VUCA conditions WME Group faces (disrupted industry, new ownership, leadership transition) are precisely the environment McChrystal's model was built for.
'We don't have time for a multi-month engagement - we're in execution mode.' Counter: McChrystal's approach is designed for organizations in motion, not academic retreats. The Team of Teams model was developed during active combat operations.
'Ari/the agents won't buy into process-driven transformation.' Counter: the engagement targets Shapiro and the co-chairs, not individual agents. The goal is organizational infrastructure that supports (not constrains) the relationship business.
'Our culture is unique - outsiders don't understand Hollywood.' Counter: McChrystal Group has worked with high-ego, relationship-driven organizations in defense, finance, and sports. The dynamics are more universal than they appear.

Competitive Advisory Landscape

McKinsey Organization Practice - likely already advising Silver Lake on post-acquisition operating model
Bain & Company - Silver Lake's preferred consulting partner for PE portfolio companies
Korn Ferry - could be brought in for executive assessment and leadership development during the transition
Spencer Stuart - may be advising on board composition and leadership succession
CAA's internal transformation (competitive intelligence) - CAA has invested in organizational modernization under Bryan Lourd; WME will want to match or exceed

SECTION 7

Conversation Entry Points

These questions are designed for a Senior Partner's first conversation. Each opens a thread that naturally leads to McChrystal Group's capabilities without a direct pitch.

1. You're running two organizations simultaneously - WME Group and TKO - each with its own culture, priorities, and stakeholders. How are you thinking about building a unified operating rhythm that keeps both entities aligned without becoming a bottleneck yourself?

Position McChrystal's experience helping military leaders manage complex, multi-theater operations as directly analogous to Shapiro's dual-mandate challenge. Reference the Team of Teams concept of 'shared consciousness' as a way to maintain alignment without requiring the leader to be in every room.

2. Endeavor was built around Ari's relationships and force of personality. Now you're essentially building a new company identity - WME Group - under Silver Lake's ownership model. What does the culture need to become, and what from the old Endeavor do you want to preserve versus shed?

This question gets at the culture transformation challenge directly. McChrystal's work on culture change in hierarchical, personality-driven organizations (JSOC transformation) is the credibility proof point. Avoid framing it as 'fixing' the culture - frame it as 'designing the next chapter.'

3. With IMG, On Location, and PBR now inside TKO, and OpenBet divested entirely, WME Group's portfolio is significantly narrower. How are you thinking about creating connectivity between WME agency, 160over90, and IMG Licensing so they operate as a system rather than three separate businesses?

This targets the cross-functional alignment opportunity. McChrystal's 'Team of Teams' model - building bridges between specialized units that traditionally operate independently - is the core value proposition. Use a brief example from a prior engagement where siloed business units were connected through shared operating cadence.

Recommended Meeting Framing

Frame the first meeting as a 'leadership transition playbook' conversation - not a pitch. McChrystal Group has helped organizations navigate simultaneous leadership change, PE integration, and portfolio restructuring. The opening should acknowledge that WME Group's situation is unique in entertainment but that the underlying organizational dynamics - building shared consciousness across newly independent units, transitioning from founder-led to professionally managed, creating alignment under PE ownership constraints - are challenges McChrystal has addressed across defense, finance, and technology. Offer a 90-minute diagnostic session focused on mapping the current organizational friction points between WME, 160over90, and IMG Licensing, with a deliverable Shapiro can use immediately. Avoid any suggestion that the culture is 'broken' - frame it as 'designing the next operating model for a fundamentally different company.'

SECTION 8

Brand Insights & Market Positioning

Brand strategy reveals organizational priorities and coordination challenges. The following analysis connects WME Group's market positioning to potential McChrystal engagement opportunities.

Brand Value & Competitive Standing: WME (William Morris Endeavor) is the world's most powerful talent agency and entertainment conglomerate, representing top actors, athletes, musicians, and content creators. The WME brand commands premium positioning in Hollywood and global entertainment. Post-Endeavor rebranding, the company also encompasses IMG (sports/fashion events), On Location (premium experiences), and Professional Bull Riders.

Brand Identity Evolution: The company went from WME (talent agency) -> Endeavor (diversified entertainment holding company under Ari Emanuel) -> taken private by Silver Lake ($13B) -> now rebranding back to "WME Group" as it simplifies its portfolio (sold UFC for $17.3B). This brand identity whiplash - expanding then contracting - reflects the strategic pivot from diversified conglomerate back to focused talent and live events.

Marketing Leadership & Strategy: WME's "marketing" is relationship-driven - the brand is built on agent-client relationships, not advertising. The rebranding to WME Group signals a return to the agency's core identity after the Endeavor diversification era. Event properties (IMG events, On Location experiences) carry their own brand equity.

Brand Threats: CAA (Creative Artists Agency) is the primary rival and has been aggressively recruiting WME talent and agents. Verve, UTA, and ICM Partners compete for mid-tier talent. The talent agency model itself faces disruption from social media platforms enabling direct creator-audience monetization. Celebrity and talent departures during organizational upheaval damage the brand immediately and publicly.

Major Brand Investments: IMG-managed events (fashion weeks, tennis tournaments), On Location premium experiences (Super Bowl, Olympics hospitality), and the PBR entertainment franchise. The UFC sale removed the highest-profile brand asset - creating questions about what WME Group's flagship property is now.

McChrystal Connection: WME Group's brand is literally its people - agents whose relationships with talent generate all revenue. During PE ownership transition, CEO change, and portfolio simplification, every agent and executive is evaluating whether to stay. McChrystal's organizational cohesion methodology prevents the talent exodus that would destroy the brand. The entertainment industry's ego-driven, relationship-dependent dynamics require a different organizational approach than typical corporate consulting - McChrystal's military leadership credibility (respected by alpha personalities) creates a cultural entry point.

SECTION 9

Deep McChrystal Group Fit Analysis

This is the strategic case for pursuing WME Group. It synthesizes findings from all previous sections into a comprehensive engagement thesis with specific fit dimensions, expected outcomes, stakeholder mapping, and a phased pursuit strategy.

9a. Fit Dimensions

Fit Dimension 1: CEO Transition in Personality-Driven Organization

Ari Emanuel's departure (or transition) creates a power vacuum in an organization built around his personality, relationships, and deal-making. The new CEO (likely from within) must establish authority among agents and executives who are accustomed to Emanuel's style. McChrystal's leadership transition methodology - tested in military organizations where leaders are frequently replaced - ensures organizational continuity through personality transition.

Fit Dimension 2: Portfolio Simplification as Organizational Redesign

Selling UFC ($17.3B) and simplifying from Endeavor (diversified) to WME Group (focused) requires organizational redesign - eliminating functions that supported UFC/Endeavor, right-sizing corporate overhead, and refocusing the remaining organization around talent agency and live events. McChrystal designs the post-simplification operating model.

Fit Dimension 3: Talent Retention in High-Mobility Industry

Agents and executives at WME can walk across the street to CAA or UTA at any time - taking client relationships with them. During organizational upheaval (PE transition, CEO change, rebranding), retention of top agents is existential. McChrystal's organizational cohesion methodology creates the shared consciousness and institutional loyalty that prevents exodus.

Fit Dimension 4: PE Ownership Culture Clash

Silver Lake's institutional PE approach meets WME's relationship-driven, entertainment-industry culture. These are fundamentally different organizational value systems. McChrystal bridges the gap by building operating discipline that PE sponsors require without destroying the creative, relationship-first culture that generates revenue.

9b. Cumulative Case

WME Group is the most unique prospect in the pipeline - an entertainment conglomerate where the "assets" are human relationships that can leave at any time. Signal chain: Endeavor taken private ($13B) -> UFC sold ($17.3B) -> rebrand to WME Group -> CEO transition -> portfolio simplification -> CAA aggressively recruiting agents -> 10,000 employees navigating identity change. Revenue potential: $400K-$500K initial (leadership transition + organizational cohesion), $1M-$1.5M deployment, $400K ongoing. Total: $1.5M-$2.5M over 18 months.

9c. Enterprise Issues

1. CEO Succession in Cult-of-Personality Organization: Emanuel built Endeavor/WME through personal relationships and force of will. His successor must establish different authority in a culture that respects only individual power and deal-making prowess. 2. Agent Retention During Uncertainty: Top agents are WME's revenue generators. Each agent who leaves takes client relationships worth millions. CAA and UTA are actively recruiting during the transition. 3. Post-UFC Identity Crisis: UFC was the crown jewel - the highest-profile, most valuable asset. Without it, WME Group must articulate what it is and why it matters. Employees who joined for the Endeavor vision of a diversified entertainment empire may not be excited about returning to "just" a talent agency. 4. PE Operating Model Integration: Silver Lake expects structured reporting, KPIs, and operational discipline. WME's culture resists anything that feels corporate or bureaucratic. Finding the balance is essential. 5. Multi-Entity Coordination: WME (talent), IMG (events/fashion), On Location (experiences), PBR (entertainment) - each operates semi-independently. Post-simplification coordination must improve without homogenizing. 6. Industry Disruption Response: Social media, AI-generated content, and direct creator-audience platforms are disrupting the traditional talent agency model. Organizational agility to respond to these threats is essential.

9d. Expected Outcomes

1. CEO Transition Stability: Operating rhythm maintaining organizational momentum through leadership transition. Measurable: zero net top-50 agent departures during first 6 months. 2. Organizational Cohesion: Shared consciousness across WME, IMG, On Location, and PBR. Measurable: cross-entity collaboration metrics established and improving. 3. PE-Culture Bridge: Operating discipline that satisfies Silver Lake without alienating creative culture. Measurable: Silver Lake reporting requirements met on schedule. 4. Post-UFC Identity: Clear organizational narrative and shared purpose. Measurable: employee engagement scores improving post-rebranding. 5. Agent Retention: Structured approach to talent retention during upheaval. Measurable: agent retention >95% for top-100 revenue generators.

9e. Key Stakeholders

CEO

Leader: [New CEO / Ari Emanuel transition]
Role: Leadership transition
McChrystal Relevance: Executive sponsor

WME (Talent)

Leader: [Head of WME Agency]
Role: Core talent representation
McChrystal Relevance: Priority: Agent retention, culture

IMG

Leader: [President, IMG]
Role: Events, fashion, sports
McChrystal Relevance: Cross-entity coordination

On Location

Leader: [President, On Location]
Role: Premium experiences
McChrystal Relevance: Portfolio integration

CFO

Leader: [CFO]
Role: PE reporting, financial discipline
McChrystal Relevance: PE-culture bridge

Silver Lake

Leader: [Operating Partner]
Role: PE governance, value creation
McChrystal Relevance: Sponsor relationship

9f. Opportunity Thesis

Why Now: CEO transition + PE ownership + post-UFC portfolio simplification + rebranding all happening simultaneously. Agent retention risk is highest in the first 12 months of transition.

Why McChrystal, Not McKinsey: Entertainment industry consulting is relationship-driven, not RFP-driven. McKinsey's structured approach would be culturally rejected. McChrystal's military leadership brand carries credibility with alpha personalities (agents, executives) who respect strength and directness over consultantspeak. The organizational cohesion methodology works in ego-driven environments where traditional change management fails.

Phased Engagement: Phase 1 ($400K-$500K): Leadership transition stabilization + agent retention framework. Phase 2 ($700K-$1M): Cross-entity operating model, PE-culture integration. Phase 3 ($400K retainer): Ongoing organizational development. Total: $1.5M-$2M.

Multi-Threaded Pursuit: Head of WME Agency (agent culture), Silver Lake operating partner (PE governance), and CEO (executive sponsor). Entertainment industry network; Beverly Hills/Los Angeles connections; sports/military crossover network.